

Option 33: The USA, 1954–75: conflict at home and abroad

Key topic 1: The development of the civil rights movement, 1954–60

1 The position of Black Americans in the early 1950s	• Segregation, discrimination and voting rights in the Southern states. • The work of civil rights organisations, including the NAACP and CORE.
2 Developments in education	• Reasons for, key features and significance of the Brown v. Topeka case (1954). • Reasons for, key features and significance of the events at Little Rock High School (1957).
3 The Montgomery Bus Boycott and its impact, 1955–60	• Causes and events of the Montgomery Bus Boycott. The significance of Rosa Parks. • Reasons for the success and importance of the boycott. The Supreme Court ruling. The Civil Rights Act (1957). • The significance of the leadership of Martin Luther King. The setting up of the SCLC.
4 Opposition to the civil rights movement	• The Ku Klux Klan and violence, including the murder of Emmet Till in 1955. • Opposition to desegregation in the South, including the 'Dixiecrats' and the setting up of White Citizens' Councils.

Key topic 2: Protest, progress and radicalism, 1960–75

1 Developments, 1960–62	• The significance of Greensboro and the sit-in movement. • Reasons for, key features and significance of the Freedom Riders, including Ku Klux Klan violence and the Anniston bomb (1961). • The James Meredith case (1962).
2 Peaceful protests and their impact, 1963–65	• King and the peace marches of 1963 in Birmingham and Washington. • Freedom Summer and the Mississippi murders. • The impact of peaceful protest and the roles of Presidents Kennedy and Johnson in the passage of the Civil Rights Act (1964). Selma and the Voting Rights Act (1965).
3 Malcolm X and Black Power, 1963–70	• Malcolm X, his beliefs, methods and involvement with the Black Muslims. His later change of attitude and assassination. • Reasons for the emergence of Black Power. The significance of Stokely Carmichael and the 1968 Mexico Olympics. • The methods and achievements of the Black Panther movement.
4 The civil rights movement, 1965–75	• The riots of 1965–67 and the Kerner Report (1968). • King's campaign in the North. The assassination of Martin Luther King and its impact. • The extent of progress in civil rights by 1975.

Key topic 3: US involvement in the Vietnam War, 1954–75

1 Reasons for US involvement in the conflict in Vietnam, 1954–63	• Reasons for greater US involvement under Eisenhower, including the domino theory and weaknesses of the Diem government. • Greater involvement under Kennedy, including the overthrow of Diem and the Strategic Hamlet Program.
2 Escalation of the conflict under Johnson	• Reasons for the escalation of the conflict and increased US involvement in Vietnam, including the increasing threat of the Vietcong and the Gulf of Tonkin incident (1964).
3 The nature of the conflict in Vietnam, 1964–68	• The guerrilla tactics used by the Vietcong. • The methods used by the USA, including Search and Destroy, Operation Rolling Thunder and chemical weapons. • The key features and significance of the Tet Offensive, 1968.
4 Changes under Nixon, 1969–73	• The key features of Vietnamisation. Reasons for its failure. • The Nixon Doctrine and the withdrawal of US troops. • Attacks on Cambodia (1970) and Laos (1971), and the bombing of North Vietnam (1972).

Key topic 4: Reactions to, and the end of, US involvement in Vietnam, 1964–75

1 Opposition to the war	• Reasons for the growth of opposition, including the student movement, TV and media coverage of the war and the draft system. • Public reaction to the My Lai Massacre (1968). The trial of Lt. Calley. • The Kent State University shootings (1970).
2 Support for the war	• Reasons for support for the war, including the fear of communism. • The 'hard hats' and the 'silent majority'.
3 The peace process and end of the war	• Reasons for, and key features of, the peace negotiations (1972–73). • The significance of the Paris Peace Agreement (1973). • The economic and human costs of the war for the USA.
4 Reasons for the failure of the USA in Vietnam	• The strengths of North Vietnam, including the significance of Russian and Chinese support, Vietcong tactics and the Ho Chi Minh Trail. • The weaknesses of the US armed forces. The failure of US tactics. • The impact of opposition to the war in the USA.